Analysis of the Ḵẖamriyyah (The Wine Song) of Shaykh 'Umar Ibn Al-Fāriḍ

Executive Summary

The *Ḵẖamriyyah*, or "Wine Song," authored by Shaykh 'Umar Ibn Al-Fāriḍ (577–632 A.H.), is a seminal work of Sufi literature that utilizes the metaphor of wine-drinking to describe spiritual ecstasy and divine gnosis. This briefing document synthesizes the poem's core themes, focusing on its allegorical framework, the miraculous transformative powers attributed to this "divine wine," and its philosophical assertions regarding divine immanence and pre-eternity.

Key takeaways include:

- **Allegorical Intent:** Every element of a traditional drinking scene (cup, sun, tavern, intoxication) is mapped to a specific spiritual reality, such as the Prophet, divine love, or God's creation.
- **Transcendental Origin:** The "wine" is described as pre-existing all of creation, including time and the physical vineyard.
- **Healing and Restoration:** The poem claims that even the mere mention, fragrance, or sight of the wine's seal can heal physical ailments, restore reason, and revive the dead.
- **Moral Inversion:** Unlike literal wine, which causes shame and sin, this divine wine produces courage, generosity, and clemency.

Symbolic Framework and Allegories

The poem operates on a complex system of symbols where material objects represent metaphysical truths. The following table outlines the primary allegorical definitions provided in the text:

Material Symbol	Spiritual Reality
The Beloved	The Prophet Muhammad or the Creator (the source of love).
Wine	Divine knowledge, love of the Divinity, and the essence of the "Absolute Spirit."
Intoxication	Spiritual ecstasy.
The Cup	The "full moon," representing the Prophet.
The Sun	The divine wine itself.

The Crescent	The "learned" or spiritual scholars who hand the wine round.
The Tavern	God's creation and the designated place for *Dhikr* (remembrance of God).
Dilution (with water)	The various religions of the world.
Stars/Bubbles	The teachers of various religions.
The Seal/Stopper	A guarantee of spiritual quality; even looking at it or kissing it provides wisdom.

The Nature and Pre-existence of the Divine Wine

Ibn Al-Fāriḍ emphasizes that this spiritual wine is not a product of time but a fundamental reality that predates existence.

- **Pre-eternity:** The poet asserts they drank this wine "ere the vineyard was created." It existed in the "long past" when there was no shape or form.
- **Absolute Priority:** The text states, "Before It there was no before, and there is no after, after its after." While time is a finite, created thing, the wine represents the infinite Absolute Spirit.
- **Physical Attributes (Paradoxical):** The wine possesses "limpidity, but not of water," "softness, but not of air," and "luminosity, but not of fire." It is described as "spirit, but without body."
- **Essence through Age:** In traditional wine-making, age improves quality. Consequently, this wine, being "older than any," is presented as the "best of all."

Miraculous and Transformative Powers

A significant portion of the *Ḵẖamriyyah* is dedicated to the wine's ability to reverse hopeless conditions and perform miracles.

Physical and Mental Healing

- **Revival of the Dead:** If the wine were sprinkled on a grave, the dead would rise with a revived body (a reference to the raising of Lazarus).
- **Restoration of Senses:** The fragrance can return the power of smell to those deprived of it; the sight can restore vision to the blind; and the sound of it being poured can make the deaf hear.

- **Curing Ailments:** The shadow of its vineyard cures the sick, and being near its "abode" allows the paralytic to walk.
- **Mental Clarity:** If a "wizard" (representing a teacher) writes the letters of the wine's name on the forehead of a madman, his reason is restored. Even an "idiot" kissing the stopper of the wine becomes wise.

Moral and Ethical Elevation

The text explicitly contrasts the effects of this divine wine with the "shameful" and "sinful" effects of literal wine-drinking (which is forbidden in the Qur'an).

- **Virtue Induction:** It makes the cowardly strong, the miserly generous, and the ill-tempered clement, even under provocation.
- **Spiritual Joy:** Simply mentioning its name brings joy and causes sorrow to depart, akin to a lover hearing the name of a beloved.

Theological and Philosophical Perspectives

The poem touches upon the relationship between the Creator, the soul, and different faith traditions.

- **Divine Immanence:** The poem suggests that "by It all things had their being" and that God is immanent in all things, described as "the tree in the seed." This is distinguished from pantheism (the belief that the Universe is God).
- **Spiritual Union:** The poet describes their soul as being "one with It," though the text clarifies this as "agreement" rather than a physical "mixing" of substances.
- **Perspective on Other Faiths:** The "Convent's dwellers" (Christian mystics and monks) are described as being intoxicated by the wine's aspiration, though the text suggests they were "not thorough in their endeavour" compared to the Prophet's path.
- **The Injunction to Drink:** While literal wine is a sin, the poet argues that *not* drinking this divine wine would be the true sin: "Never, but rather that which, it would be a sin, not to drink."

Symbolic Banners and Sufi Practice

The text describes Sufi leaders using banners inscribed with specific virtues, fueled by the "intoxication" of the divine name:

- **Followers of Al-Kaylānī:** Inscribed with "Humility and Contrition."

- **Followers of Ibn 'Arabī:** Inscribed with "Useful learning and Ennobling action."
- **Followers of Al-Shādhilī:** Inscribed with "Abandonment of Artifices."

Final Conclusion of the Work

The poem concludes with a stark warning and a call to action for the seeker. True happiness in this world is only found through this spiritual "drunkenness." To live "sober" (without spiritual ecstasy) is to miss the "benefit of resolution." Those who spend their lives without a "lot or share" in this divine wine are advised to "bewail [their] fate," as they have wasted their existence.